

# Minimum Viable Product (MVP)

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*The smallest solution that starts the build–measure–learn loop*

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

An MVP is the smallest, cheapest version of a product that lets a team begin the **build–measure–learn** loop with real users and validated learning. It is not a smaller product but a learning device: the least you can build to test your riskiest assumption.

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Popularised by Eric Ries in *The Lean Startup* (2011), drawing on Steve Blank's customer-development method.

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Startups waste resources building full products nobody wants. The MVP minimises time and cost to first validated learning, so teams pivot or persevere on evidence.

## HOW IT IS USED

Identify the riskiest assumption, build the minimum needed to test it (which may be a landing page or concierge service, not code), measure real behaviour, and learn.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Prototyping and early validation, before scaling a build.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, product managers and innovation teams.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It reframes the prototype as an **experiment** rather than a draft product, embedding scientific method into product development.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

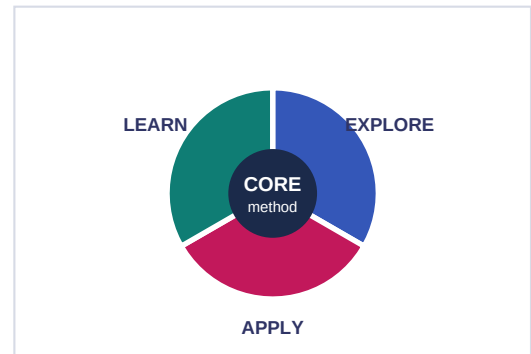


Figure 1. Minimum Viable Product (MVP) framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Paper / Low-fi Prototype *Slibrary 8*

A/B Testing *Slibrary 9*

Critical Items Diagram *Slibrary 6*

## SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Ries, E. (2011) *The Lean Startup*. New York: Crown Business.

Blank, S. (2013) 'Why the Lean Start-Up Changes Everything', *Harvard Business Review*, 91(5), pp. 63–72.